

Louisville - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | ACC

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ♦ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	Top-30 / upper-tier ACC contender with a defense good enough to carry stretches, but an unproven new starting quarterback, a nearly rebuilt offensive line, early receiver absences and legally fluid defensive availability create a wider preseason range than the No. 24 AP ranking suggests.
Preseason consensus	AP No. 24 (194 points) · SP+ No. 27
Returning production	55% (No. 59) overall · Off. 54% (No. 68) · Def. 55% (No. 62)
Primer power rating	+11.0 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	7.8 wins · likely 8-4
Net vs. 2025	● ↔ Similar - Similar overall quality with more offensive volatility: the defense still projects as the stabilizer, while QB, OL and receiver turnover make the offense less proven even with RB Isaac Brown returning.
Confidence	Medium-low

2026 identity: Jeff Brohm builds around RB Isaac Brown/QB Lincoln Kienholz, while DC Mark Ivey keeps an aggressive defense around DL Clev Lubin. OL cohesion and defensive availability are the main swing variables.

Bottom line: Louisville can stay in the ACC race, but rebuilt QB/OL roles and multiple availability questions widen the range beyond a typical top-25 team.

Beats expectations if: QB Lincoln Kienholz is efficient, the rebuilt OL keeps RB Isaac Brown on schedule, and Ivey preserves the 2025 defense's top-25 efficiency.

Disappoints if: OL/WR turnover recreates 2025 down-to-down problems and defensive availability erodes depth.

Five things to remember

- 2025 baseline:** The 2025 defense was top-25 in adjusted rating, EPA/play, success rate and explosive-play prevention.
- Quarterback:** QB Lincoln Kienholz is the expected starter; Jeff Brohm still calls the offense, and Kienholz adds mobility but limited proven starting production.
- ★ **RB Isaac Brown:** RB Isaac Brown is the offensive anchor with first-team ACC, Maxwell and Walter Camp recognition.
- Offensive line:** The OL returns one starter, OL Lance Robinson; OL Anwar O'Neal's health and tackle/center competition shape the final five.
- Secondary:** LB Kris Hughes/DB Montavin Quisenberry have early availability losses, while DB D'Angelo Hutchinson/DB Jabari Mack carry fluid legal availability.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	9-4 (4-4 ACC)	● Good
Scoring	29.9 PPG	● Good / above average
Total offense	384.5 YPG	● Average / mixed
Rush offense	163.9 YPG · 5.1 YPC	● Average / mixed
Pass efficiency	6.86 YPA · 18 TD / 9 INT	● Average / mixed
Third downs	35.5%	● Below average
Scoring defense	21.2 PPG allowed	● Good / above average
Total defense	303.1 YPG allowed	● Very good
Rush defense	114.3 YPG · 3.5 YPC	● Very good
Pass defense	188.8 YPG · 6.00 YPA · 15 TD allowed	● Very good

Louisville's 9-4 record leaned on defense (No. 16 total, No. 17 pass efficiency); the offense was No. 71 total/No. 74 pass efficiency/No. 104 on third down.

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	+3.84 · No. 35	● Very good
Off. EPA/play	+0.022 · No. 59	● Average / mixed
Off. success rate	45.6% · No. 39	● Good / above average
Off. explosive-play rate	12.2% · No. 63	● Average / mixed
Havoc allowed	16.6% · No. 99	● Below average
Opp.-adjusted defense	+6.36 · No. 20	● Very good
Def. EPA/play allowed	-0.105 · No. 25	● Very good
Def. success rate allowed	36.8% · No. 18	● Very good
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	9.8% · No. 20	● Very good
Havoc created	17.2% · No. 33	● Very good

Advanced-stat read: Defense was top-25 across adjusted rating, EPA, success rate and explosive prevention. Offense was less stable, so 2026 hinges on protecting the new QB/OL structure well enough for RB Isaac Brown and the defense to carry efficiency.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC / offensive play-caller	Jeff Brohm - Returning HC; offensive play-caller	● ↔ Jeff Brohm remains the offensive play-caller, keeping the program's game-day identity stable.
OC	Brian Brohm - Returning offensive coordinator/QBs coach	● ↔ Brian Brohm's return preserves QB/offensive coordination continuity under Jeff Brohm's play-calling.
Co-DC / corners	◆ Steve Ellis - Internal promotion to co-defensive coordinator	● ↔ Steve Ellis' internal promotion adds coordinator responsibility without forcing a wholesale defensive reset.
Co-DC / defensive play-caller	◆ Mark Ivey - Internal promotion; defensive play-caller	● ↔ Mark Ivey's internal promotion preserves staff continuity while establishing him as the defensive play-caller.

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ QB Lincoln Kienholz	Ohio State	● ↔ Expected QB1 with useful mobility but limited proven Power 4 starting production.
◆ WR Tre Richardson	Vanderbilt	● ↑ First-group receiver with Biletnikoff/Paul Hornung recognition.
◆ WR Lawayne McCoy	Florida State	● ↔ Adds a major option to the rebuilt receiver room.
◆ OL Cason Henry / OL Anwar O’Neal / OL Eryx Daugherty / OL Evan Wibberley / OL Johnnie Brown III	South Carolina / Delaware / Boston College / Kentucky / Georgia Southern	● ↔ Transfer volume gives the rebuilt line options; the final five remains unsettled.

Out	To	Loss
QB Miller Moss	2026 Louisville Pro Day / NFL evaluation	● ↓ Starting QB departs; QB Lincoln Kienholz takes over.
WR Chris Bell	NFL (Miami), Round 3, No. 94	● ↓ Major veteran receiver loss.
WR Caullin Lacy	NFL (New York Jets), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Another veteran receiver departs.
OL Jordan Church / OL Mahamane Moussa	Texas Tech / professional evaluation	● ↓ Two OL departures deepen the line rebuild.

Offense net: ● ↓ RB Isaac Brown anchors an offense replacing the starting QB, multiple receivers and most of the OL.

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ S Koen Entringer	Iowa	● ↑ Projected safety leader with Nagurski recognition.
◆ DL Jerod Smith II / DL Demeco Kennedy	Kentucky / Purdue	● ↔ Add needed front depth.
◆ DB D’Angelo Hutchinson / DB Jabari Mack	Louisville return	● ↑ Raise the secondary ceiling, with legal availability still fluid.

Out	To	Loss
DL Rene Konga / DL Jordan Guerad / DL Denzel Lowry	2026 professional evaluation	● ↓ Multiple front contributors depart.
LB TJ Quinn	2026 professional evaluation	● ↓ Major LB departure raises the burden on LB Stanquan Clark.

Defense net: ● ↔ Strong 2025 base and key anchors remain, but front-seven losses and fluid DB D’Angelo Hutchinson/DB Jabari Mack/LB Kalib Perry statuses limit continuity.

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	Brohm-called offense expected to lean on RB Isaac Brown while using Kienholz's mobility to add read-option stress.	Brown/Keyjuan Brown backfield quality, Brohm's play-calling continuity and a refreshed first-group receiver set.	A nearly rebuilt OL and early receiver availability could amplify the 2025 havoc-allowed and third-down weaknesses.
Defense	Ivey-led aggressive defense that intends to use pressure while retaining situational restraint.	DL Clev Lubin and a 2025 profile that was top-25 in opponent-adjusted defense, EPA allowed, success rate allowed and explosive prevention.	Replacing several front-seven/secondary contributors while legal and safety-role uncertainty remain unresolved.
Special teams	Not a defining preseason identity; SP+ projects a roughly middle-of-the-pack unit.	No major negative model signal; overall special-teams rating is slightly positive.	No high-confidence specialist advantage stands out comparable to the offense/defense anchors.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● B–	● ↓	Medium	QB Lincoln Kienholz is the expected starter; mobility helps, but proven Power 4 starting production is limited.
RB	● A–	● ↔	High	RB Isaac Brown is the offense's premium anchor, with RB Keyjuan Brown supporting a strong backfield.
WR	● B–	● ↓	Medium-low	WR Tre Richardson/WR Lawayne McCoy lead a rebuilt group after multiple veteran departures and early availability issues.
TE	● B	● ↔	Medium-high	TE Brody Foley/TE Jaleel Skinner give Louisville credible options without carrying the offense's main replacement burden.
OL	● C+	● ↓	Medium-low	OL Lance Robinson is the only returning starter; health and open tackle/center combinations make this the clearest offensive risk.
DL/Edge	● B+	● ↔	Medium	DL Clev Lubin anchors a strong 2025 defense while several front contributors are replaced.
LB	● B	● ↓	Medium	LB Stanquan Clark provides veteran leadership after LB TJ Quinn's departure; LB Kalib Perry's status adds uncertainty.
Secondary	● B	● ↔	Medium-low	S Koen Entringer adds a recognized anchor, but open roles and fluid legal availability lower certainty.
Special teams	● B–	● ↔	Medium-low	SP+ projects a roughly middle-of-the-pack unit without a clear specialist edge.
Coaching	● B+	● ↔	High	HC Jeff Brohm remains the offensive caller; internal DC Mark Ivey/Steve Ellis promotions preserve staff continuity.
Overall	● B+	● ↔	Medium-low	Top-30 ACC contender with a strong defense but wide variance from QB, OL, receiver and defensive-availability questions.

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: official conference honors and major award watchlists through Aug. 23, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Isaac Brown	RB	● National-level ACC star	ACC Preseason 1st team · Maxwell · Walter Camp Player of the Year	The offense's safest premium player and lead back; his efficiency can protect a new quarterback and line.
Clev Lubin	DL	● High-end conference defender	ACC Preseason 1st team · Bednarik · Nagurski	The most decorated returning front player and key anchor for a defense replacing several NFL/pro contributors.
◆ Lincoln Kienholz (TR: Ohio State)	QB	● Unproven / system-fit starter projection	-	Expected starter whose mobility adds a read-option dimension; his transition from projection to proven Power 4 starter is the biggest team-level variable.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
◆ Tre Richardson (TR: Vanderbilt)	WR	● High-upside first-group transfer	Biletnikoff · Paul Hornung	Expected first-group receiver and a central replacement for the veteran pass-catchers lost after 2025.
Koen Entringer	S	● High-end conference starter	Nagurski	Projected safety leader with national award recognition; central to stabilizing a secondary with open roles and legal-status complexity.
Lance Robinson	OL	● Critical returning OL anchor	Outland	The only returning OL starter and the piece whose LT/center flexibility determines several other lineup choices.
Stanquan Clark	LB	● Veteran defensive leader	-	Current linebacker reporting identifies him as a veteran leader after an injury-limited 2025; important after TJ Quinn's departure.
D'Angelo Hutchinson	DB	● Meaningful return with legal availability risk	-	A meaningful current participant under temporary Kentucky-court protection; his ultimate availability remains fluid.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	● Manageable by upper-tier ACC standards rather than championship-brutal: the neutral Ole Miss opener is the highest-end test, while the league slate is defined more by a large cluster of swingable games than repeated top-15 opponents.
Difficulty	● 6/10 · Moderate · SP+ SOS No. 60
Hardest stretch	SMU → Wake Forest → at NC State → Florida State → at Syracuse. It is a five-game run without a bye and with four Power 4 opponents before the open week; Ole Miss remains the single hardest game.
Swing games	vs SMU, at NC State, vs Florida State, at Georgia Tech, at Kentucky
Advantage	Louisville avoids a SP+ top-15 ACC opponent and gets its only bye before Stanford; six home games plus a neutral opener keep the travel burden moderate.
Expected	7.8 wins · likely 8-4
Floor / ceiling	6-6 / 10-2

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	Treat Louisville as strong-defense/volatile-offense: avoid prices assuming immediate QB/OL continuity and prefer discounts that reflect the uncertainty.
Back them when	The rebuilt OL has a favorable matchup, RB Isaac Brown can drive early downs and Ivey's pressure package can create negatives.
Fade/pass when	Strong fronts can force obvious passing downs or defensive availability materially thins Ivey's flexibility.
Key monitor	QB Lincoln Kienholz performance/role stability, OL Anwar O'Neal health and final OL five, DB Montavin Quisenberry return timing, DB D'Angelo Hutchinson / DB Jabari Mack legal availability, LB Kalib Perry legal/eligibility status, live market/injuries/weather
Week 1 baseline	Louisville +5.5 vs. Ole Miss (neutral) · rating-only baseline; Louisville primer +11.0 minus Ole Miss primer +16.5; no home-field, matchup or availability adjustment. Compare with the live market before betting. Live market: Louisville +6.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

Louisville has an ACC-contender foundation because RB Isaac Brown is a premium offensive anchor, Jeff Brohm remains the play-caller, and a 2025 top-25-caliber defense returns key pieces such as DL Clev Lubin while adding S Koen Entringer. QB Lincoln Kienholz's mobility gives the new offense another dimension.

The range is wider than the No. 24 AP label suggests because the OL is nearly rebuilt, the receiver group is changing, and several defensive availability questions remain fluid. The **7.8-win / 8-4** baseline fits a team capable of staying in the ACC

race if the new line protects well enough and the defense retains its 2025 efficiency.

About this primer

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Sources: [2026 roster](#) · [coaching](#) · [camp / roles](#) · [scheme](#) · [departures](#) · [2025 context](#)

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